



// GUIDE — AI-AGENTS-101

How to Automate Your *Manual Work* with AI Agents

A practical guide for business owners — from identifying what to automate, to building your first agent, to running it without technical headaches.

- Invoice processing
- Social media content
- Lead research at scale
- Appointment follow-ups
- CRM data entry
- Customer support replies
- Proposal drafts
- Review requests

PATH 01 // DIY

Build it yourself with Claude

Set up a Project, add context, connect MCP tools. Powerful — but comes with real limitations worth knowing.

PATH 02 // DONE-FOR-YOU

Let Talk to me Data build it

Describe the work in plain language. We design, build, host, and run the agent — zero tokens, zero setup, zero limits.

The work that doesn't need a person is still done by a person.

Every business owner has a stack of recurring tasks that are perfectly defined, completely predictable, and entirely repetitive. You could write down the steps once and hand them to someone forever. That's exactly what an AI agent does — except it never clocks off, never forgets the steps, and never gets distracted. Here's what that looks like in practice.



Invoice processing & bookkeeping

Vendor invoices arrive by email, get downloaded, the numbers get typed into accounting software by hand. Line items, totals, categories — every field, every time.

Manual: 20-40 min/invoice

Agent: reads, categorizes & posts automatically



Social media content creation

Turning a blog post, product update, or weekly insight into 5 platform-specific posts takes a chunk of every week — and it's the same formula each time.

Manual: 2-3 hrs/week

Agent: drafts, formats & schedules per platform



Lead research at scale

Finding the right companies, pulling contact info, checking LinkedIn, writing a personalised first line — done one prospect at a time, for hours, before a single email gets sent.

Manual: 10-15 min per lead

Agent: researches & enriches hundreds overnight



Follow-up sequences & outreach

Leads who expressed interest but didn't convert go quiet because no one had time to follow up consistently. Proposals go out and then... silence.

Manual: inconsistent or forgotten

Agent: timed, personalised sequences — always sent



CRM & data entry

After every call or email, someone has to update the CRM — status, notes, next steps. It's always the last thing that gets done, and often doesn't.

Manual: 5-10 min per contact

Agent: logs & updates in real time



Review requests & re-engagement

Happy customers rarely leave a review unless someone asks at exactly the right moment. Past customers go quiet because there's no consistent reason to reach back out.

Manual: hit-or-miss timing

Agent: triggered at the perfect moment, every time

// CLAUDE DESKTOP — PROJECT SETUP

You can build your first agent in Claude today — here's exactly how.

Claude's desktop app lets you create persistent "Projects" that remember context between sessions and connect to real tools via MCP (Model Context Protocol). Here's the setup flow that gets an agent running.

1 Open Claude Desktop → Create a New Project

In the left sidebar, click "New Project". Give it a name that reflects the workflow — e.g. "Invoice Processor" or "Lead Research Agent". This project will hold all the context and instructions for this specific agent.

2 Add context & instructions to the Project Knowledge

Inside the project, open "Project Knowledge" and paste in your instructions. Be specific: describe the task, the format you want outputs in, any rules the agent must follow, and examples of what good looks like.

Example instruction for a social content agent:

"You are a social media assistant for [Business Name]. When given a topic or URL, create: (1) a LinkedIn post of 150-200 words with a hook and 3 bullet points, (2) a Twitter/X thread of 5 tweets, (3) an Instagram caption with 5 relevant hashtags. Always write in first person, professional but conversational."

3 Connect tools via MCP (Model Context Protocol)

MCP lets Claude connect to real apps — Google Drive, Gmail, Notion, Airtable, LinkedIn, QuickBooks, and more. In Claude's settings, go to "Integrations" and enable the tools your workflow needs. Once connected, the agent can read from, write to, and trigger actions in those apps.

4 Start a conversation inside the project & run the workflow

With the project open, start a new chat. Claude will automatically use your Project Knowledge as its operating instructions. Give it a trigger — "Process the invoices in the /Invoices/Pending folder" — and it will work through the task using the connected tools.

● Gmail

● Google Drive

● Notion

● Airtable

● QuickBooks

● LinkedIn

● Slack

● HubSpot

● Calendly

● + hundreds more

// SEE IT IN ACTION

Watch: How to build an AI Agent from scratch

Learn how to build an AI Agent from 0 with Claude, and how Talk to Me Data is the ideal AI Agent solution for your business.



youtube.com

youtu.be/ffKQb1RacLI

talktomedata.com



// REALITY CHECK

The DIY path works — until it doesn't.

Claude Projects are genuinely powerful. But if you've tried running a long agent workflow inside Claude, you've likely run into the same set of walls. These aren't bugs — they're structural limitations of how consumer AI products work.

△ THE 5-HOUR USAGE WINDOW

Claude's consumer plans cap how much you can use the model within a rolling 5-hour window. A long agent workflow — processing 50 invoices, researching 200 leads, generating a week of content — can consume that entire window in one session. When the limit hits, the agent stops mid-task. You get a message telling you to wait.



Agents stall mid-task

When the usage window closes, the workflow stops wherever it is. Partial results, incomplete batches, inconsistent outputs — you pick up the pieces manually.



Claude becomes unavailable for you

While an agent burns through your usage window, you can't use Claude for anything else. The same tokens that run your agent are the ones you'd use to draft an email or answer a question.



API keys & infra complexity

Running agents reliably outside of the chat UI means managing API keys, rate limits, hosting, error handling, and monitoring — a part-time job in itself.

// TYPICAL 5-HOUR USAGE WINDOW — INVOICE PROCESSING AGENT (100 INVOICES)



The root issue: Claude's consumer interface is designed for conversational use — quick questions, creative tasks, back-and-forth exchanges. Persistent, autonomous agent workflows that run in the background, at scale, without supervision, need a different architecture entirely.



// TALK TO ME DATA

Describe the work in plain language. We build, deploy, and run the agent.

You shouldn't need to understand API keys, token limits, MCP configuration, or cloud hosting to automate your business. Talk to me Data handles all of it — you get the output of a running agent without the overhead of building and maintaining one.

WHAT YOU NEED	DIY WITH CLAUDE	TALK TO ME DATA
No token limits	✗ Usage windows apply	✓ Runs on our infrastructure
Agent runs 24/7	✗ Only when you're active	✓ Always-on, fully hosted
No setup required	✗ Projects, MCP, config needed	✓ Describe it — we build it
Claude still free for you	✗ Agent consumes your quota	✓ Separate — use Claude freely
No API keys to manage	✗ Required for API usage	✓ Fully managed
Monitoring & updates	✗ Your responsibility	✓ Included

01 — You describe

Tell us what to automate

In a 20-minute call, walk us through the manual task in plain language. No specs. No technical requirements. Just how you do it today.

02 — We build

We design the agent workflow

Our team maps the task, connects the tools, writes the logic, and tests it — end-to-end, ready to run.

03 — It runs

Deployed, hosted, monitored

Your agent runs on our infrastructure. No downtime, no token walls, no maintenance. You just get the work done.



// 100% CUSTOM — BUILT AROUND YOUR EXACT WORKFLOW

We don't sell templates. Every agent is built from scratch for your business.

Whether you use QuickBooks, HubSpot, Gmail, Notion, or a custom internal tool — we map your exact steps, your exact rules, and your exact tools into an agent that works the way you do. No compromise. No workarounds.

Pick the task you'd love to never do manually again.

Tell us about one task on a free 20-minute call — we'll map exactly what a custom agent would do, connected to the tools you already use, and how fast we can have it running.

// EXAMPLES OF CUSTOM AGENTS WE'VE BUILT

- ✓ Reading vendor invoices → auto-posting line items to QuickBooks or Xero
- ✓ Turning a blog post → 5 platform-specific posts, scheduled and published automatically
- ✓ Scraping a prospect list → enriched with emails, LinkedIn info, and a personalised opener
- ✓ Missed call → instant SMS reply + booked follow-up appointment, no human needed
- ✓ Completed job → review request + CRM update + invoice triggered automatically

Book a free 20-minute call →

Custom-built for your exact tools & workflow

No tech knowledge needed · Fully managed

talktomedata.com/book-demo

